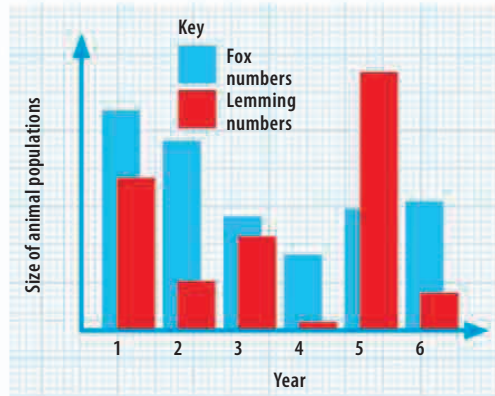


Predators and prey

Within an ecosystem, hunters and the hunted are closely linked. Their populations rise and fall in a repeating pattern. When there are a lot of prey animals, predators also increase in number, as there is more food to sustain them. However, more predators soon results in fewer prey, and the number of predators drops as there is less food available. Without many predators, the prey population rises again, and the cycle repeats.

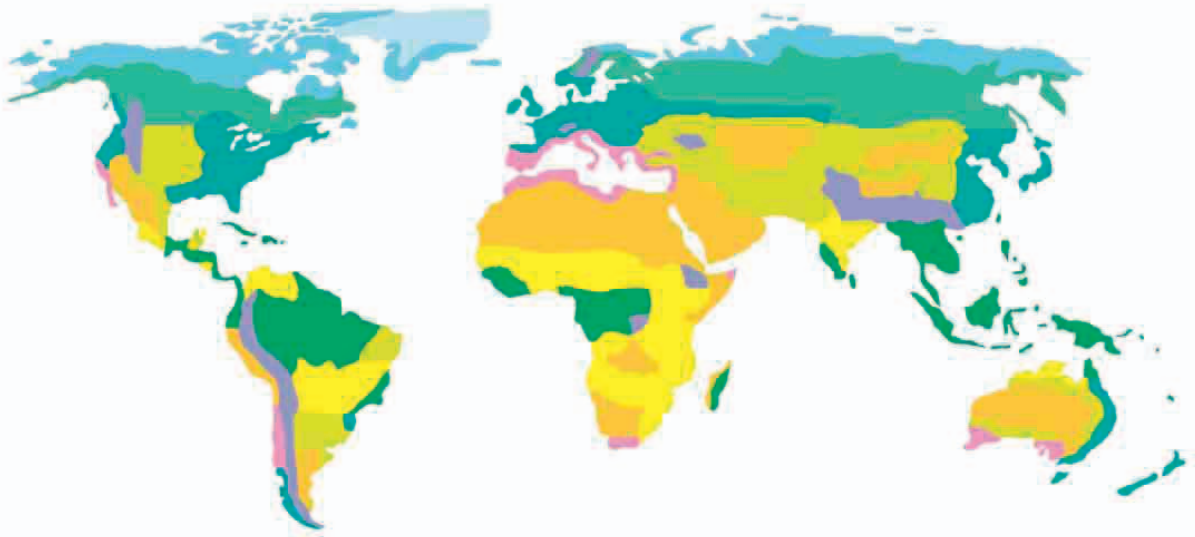


◀ Foxes and lemmings

This graph shows that, in years with high numbers of lemmings, Arctic foxes do well and have large numbers of pups. The next year, the lemming population falls as a result of this and the population of foxes decreases, too.

Biomes

The land habitats on Earth are grouped into ten climate zones, also known as biomes. Each biome is home to a particular set of animals and plants, which are adapted to the challenges of surviving in the different conditions. Desert animals must conserve water, while polar ones contend with long periods of extreme cold. Aquatic habitats are divided into marine and freshwater biomes.



Temperate forest

Trees grow in summer, before dropping their leaves and becoming dormant in winter.

Taiga

Conifer forests dominate the far north, where the cold and short summers are the main factors.

Polar

The temperature around the poles is below freezing for most of the year.

Temperate grassland

When there is too little rainfall for trees to grow, huge expanses of grass cover the land.

Savannah

In these warm, grass-covered regions, there is low rainfall and few trees.

Tropical forest

High rainfall and warm conditions all year result in thick jungles around the tropics.

Mountains

At high altitude, the air is thin (lacking oxygen) and temperatures are low.

Tundra

All but the upper layer of soil is permanently frozen, making it hard for plants to grow.

Chaparral

Also known as the Mediterranean biome, this region is filled with dry woodlands.

Desert

The driest parts of Earth have hardly any rainfall and very little vegetation.